FREE GUIDE FROM THE IMPACT PLATFORM

Inclusive Data Collection

The Inclusion Edit
Capacity. Capability. Change.

A step by step guide to collecting workforce diversity data ethically, legally, and in ways that build trust with the people you ask.

Guide About 20 minutes Updated October 2026

HOW TO USE THIS

1. Answer the two readiness questions.
2. Work through the eight steps and mark where you are on each.
3. Plan your approach in sections A to C.
4. Use your answers as the rationale for your DPIA, board paper and staff communications.

FILL IT IN ON SCREEN

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Step 1: Quick readiness check

Two questions to put this guide in context for your situation.

Has your organisation collected equality data before?

- ○ Yes, recently and regularly
- ○ Yes, but not recently
- ○ Once or twice, informally
- ○ No, this would be a first

What is your primary reason for collecting now?

- ○ To build or update an EDI strategy
- ○ To meet a reporting requirement
- ○ To investigate a specific equity concern
- ○ To understand our baseline for the first time

If this is your first time: work through all eight steps carefully, then use the planning section to set your intentions before you design your survey.
If you have collected data before: use the steps to audit and improve your existing approach, paying particular attention to step 3 (inclusive questions) and step 5 (privacy and trust). Then complete the planning section.

Step 2: Eight steps to inclusive data collection

Mark where you are on each step.

1 Key Considerations Before You Begin

Before designing your survey or choosing your platform, pause and work through these five considerations. Getting clarity here shapes every decision that follows.

- Purpose and use: what are you collecting data for, and how will it be used to drive inclusion? Be specific: vague purposes lead to vague data.
- Representation: are all groups, especially marginalised or underrepresented communities, included in the design process, not just as respondents?
- Privacy and trust: how will personal data be protected, how will confidentiality be maintained, and how will you communicate your intentions to participants?
- Intersectionality: are you capturing multiple, overlapping identities such as race, disability, gender, and age, rather than treating each in isolation?
- Avoiding harm: could the data collection process itself reinforce bias, tokenism, or stereotypes? Who has reviewed the design with this question in mind?

> **Common mistake: skipping the planning stage.** Many organisations move straight to survey design without answering these five questions first. The result is data that is hard to act on, questions that feel invasive without context, and participation rates that fall because employees do not understand why the data is being collected. These considerations are not optional extras: they are the foundation.

Where are you? ◯ Done ◯ In progress ◯ Not yet

2 Define Clear Objectives

Be specific about what you want to understand and what decisions the data will inform. Vague objectives lead to data that cannot drive change.

- Link data collection to a named outcome or equity question
- Identify who will use the data and when
- Be honest with participants about what the data will and will not be used for
- Avoid collecting data out of habit or because others do it: every data point must serve a purpose

> **Common mistake: collecting without a question.** Many organisations collect diversity data because they feel they should, without a specific question to answer. This leads to low participation, unused data, and eroded trust. If you cannot name the decision this data will inform, delay the collection until you can.

Where are you? ◯ Done ◯ In progress ◯ Not yet

3 Design Inclusive Questions

How you ask matters as much as what you ask. Inclusive question design respects the complexity of identity.

- Offer "self-describe" and "prefer not to say" options on every identity question
- Use current, community-informed language: check terminology with the communities you are asking about
- Avoid binary options on gender: include non-binary, genderqueer, and self-describe
- Ask about disability in a way that includes non-visible disabilities, chronic illness, and neurodivergence
- Separate out nationality, ethnicity, and country of birth as distinct questions
- Use pilot testing to identify questions that feel confusing, invasive, or poorly worded

Common mistake: binary gender questions. A question that offers only Male and Female excludes non-binary, gender-fluid, and intersex employees. This is not just a design flaw: it signals that the organisation does not recognise their existence. Always include at minimum: Male; Female; Non-binary; Prefer to self-describe; Prefer not to say.

Where are you? ◯ Done ◯ In progress ◯ Not yet

4 Ensure Accessibility

Your data collection method should not itself create barriers to participation.

- Ensure digital surveys are screen-reader compatible and keyboard navigable
- Offer alternatives to online-only formats where needed
- Use plain English throughout and offer translation support where relevant
- Consider the time commitment: keep surveys as short as possible while still meaningful
- Make the survey mobile-friendly

Common mistake: digital-only access. An online survey with no paper alternative excludes employees with low digital literacy, those without work devices, or those who find screen-reader-incompatible formats unusable. Low response rates in specific teams or roles can indicate an access barrier rather than low willingness to disclose.

Where are you? ◯ Done ◯ In progress ◯ Not yet

5 Protect Privacy and Build Trust

Data collection will only generate useful insights if people trust the process. Trust is built through transparency and genuine anonymity.

- Be explicit about what "anonymous" means in your context: who can see what
- Never report data in a way that could identify individuals, especially in small teams
- Store data securely and limit access to those who need it
- Tell people how long data will be retained
- Share what happened as a result of the data: close the feedback loop

Common mistake: misusing the word anonymous. Saying data is anonymous when individual responses are viewable by a line manager, or when team sizes are small enough to identify people from aggregated data, is misleading. In teams of under 10, even aggregated results can effectively identify individuals. Be specific about what anonymity means in practice and only report data at a group size where re-identification is genuinely not possible.

Where are you? ◯ Done ◯ In progress ◯ Not yet

6 Collect Intersectional Data

Single-axis data misses the complexity of lived experience. Where possible, design your analysis to surface intersectional patterns.

- Analyse data across multiple characteristics together, not just individually
- Look at pay, progression, and experience at the intersection of race and gender, for example
- Ensure your sample sizes are large enough to allow disaggregation without identifying individuals
- Acknowledge the limits of your data: what is not captured and why

Common mistake: single-axis reporting. Reporting gender data and ethnicity data separately can mask significant disparities. A pay gap analysis that shows women are paid equitably may obscure the fact that Black women are paid significantly less. Intersectional analysis requires larger sample sizes but reveals the reality that single-axis reporting hides.

Where are you? ◯ Done ◯ In progress ◯ Not yet

7 Use Data to Drive Action

Data without action is just surveillance. Commit to using what you collect to make real changes.

- Set out in advance what actions you will take based on different findings
- Report findings back to the people who provided the data
- Include data findings in your EDI strategy and board reporting
- Track change over time: collect data regularly enough to see trends
- Be honest when the data shows poor outcomes: transparency builds credibility

Common mistake: collecting without closing the loop. If employees complete a diversity survey and never hear the results, or hear results but see no action, participation rates fall sharply in future rounds. Employees are not obliged to provide data: they do so when they trust it will be used. Publish results and name what you are changing as a result, even when the findings are uncomfortable.

Where are you? ◯ Done ◯ In progress ◯ Not yet

8 Review and Iterate

Inclusive data collection is not a one-off task: it requires regular review to stay relevant, accurate, and trustworthy.

- Review your question design annually against current guidance and community feedback
- Update terminology as language evolves
- Evaluate participation rates and investigate why people choose not to respond
- Seek feedback from staff networks and ERGs on the data collection process

Common mistake: treating data collection as a one-off. A single diversity survey gives you a snapshot, not a trend. Organisations that collect data once, act on it once, and then move on lose the ability to measure whether their actions worked. Build in a regular cadence: annually at minimum, or biannually for large-scale exercises. Track participation rates as well as results: falling participation is itself an important data point.

Where are you? ◯ Done ◯ In progress ◯ Not yet

Step 3: Plan your approach

Three things to agree before you design your data collection. Together they form your data collection rationale.

A

What is the purpose of this data collection? (tick all that apply)

- [ ] To build or update an EDI strategy
- [ ] To meet a reporting or legal requirement
- [ ] To investigate a specific equity concern
- [ ] To understand our baseline for the first time
- [ ] To track progress against existing targets

B

Who will have access to the data?

- ( ) People team only, aggregated
- ( ) Senior leadership and People team
- ( ) Board and executive team
- ( ) Externally reported
- ( ) Not yet decided

Which groups may feel less safe disclosing? (tick all that apply)

- [ ] Gender identity
- [ ] Race and ethnicity
- [ ] Disability and health
- [ ] Sexual orientation
- [ ] Religion or belief
- [ ] Age
- [ ] Socioeconomic background

C

What will you do with the data, and how will it lead to change?

For example: findings will be shared in an annual transparency report, inform our inclusion strategy, and be presented to the board with named actions against each gap identified.

Review and adapt your answers to A to C before using them in a DPIA, a board paper or staff communications.

Legal and professional guidance

The landscape that governs inclusive data collection. Always seek advice specific to your organisation.

Legal frameworks and statutory guidance

Equality Act 2010 UK LAW	The foundational legislation that protects individuals from discrimination based on nine protected characteristics, including sex, race, disability, sexual orientation, and religion. It mandates equal treatment in employment and access to services. Data collection on protected characteristics must be justified, proportionate, and lawful under this framework.
UK Data Protection Act 2018 and UK GDPR UK LAW	Governs how organisations handle personal data in the UK. Sensitive categories of data, including ethnicity, disability, religion, sexual orientation, and health, are classed as 'special category data' and require either explicit consent or a specific lawful basis under Schedule 1 to process. Individuals have rights to access, correct, and erase their data. Organisations must be transparent about how data is used.
EU General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) EU	Sets strict rules for how organisations collect, store, and use personal data, especially sensitive information such as ethnicity, gender, and health. Ensures individuals have control over their data and requires organisations to be transparent, secure, and purposeful. Relevant for organisations operating across EU jurisdictions or with EU-based employees.

Industry standards

Data Protection Impact Assessment (DPIA) REQUIRED PROCESS	A structured process required by UK GDPR to identify and minimise privacy risks before launching new data processing that could significantly affect individuals' rights. Collecting sensitive equality data is likely to trigger a DPIA requirement. It helps organisations think through risk and accountability proactively, with real people in mind.
NIST Privacy Framework US/INTERNATIONAL	A voluntary, risk-based tool created by the US National Institute of Standards and Technology to help organisations identify and manage privacy risks. Flexible and adaptable across industries; useful for organisations building data systems that need to balance innovation with individual privacy protection.
CIPD / Reed Inclusion at Work 2022 BENCHMARKING	Annual benchmarking of UK employer diversity and inclusion practice, covering what is working and where the gaps are. Useful for comparing your organisation's data practices against sector peers and identifying areas for improvement in data collection design and use.

Charters and frameworks

PAS 1948: BSI Code of Practice for Creating Inclusive Workplace Culture BSI STANDARD	A free-to-download British Standards Institution standard guiding how to implement EDI frameworks in practice. Covers dimensions of diversity, inclusive design principles, recruitment and retention, and behaviour. Provides a structured approach to embedding inclusion across the employee lifecycle, including data collection practices.

National Equality Standard (NES) ACCREDITATION	A business assessment and benchmarking scheme that helps organisations evaluate their EDI policies and practices in a structured way. Achieving NES accreditation requires evidencing inclusive data practices. Useful as a benchmark for assessing where your organisation sits and what good looks like.

This guidance is for information only and is not legal advice. It focuses on UK law. Organisations in Bermuda, the US or elsewhere should check their local data protection and equality law, for example Bermuda's Personal Information Protection Act 2016.

Why data collection is central to inclusion progress

You cannot manage what you do not measure. Collecting data on workforce diversity is a foundational step in any credible inclusion strategy: it establishes a baseline, allows progress to be tracked, and makes it possible to identify where specific groups are being disproportionately affected by organisational processes. Without data, inclusion work risks being driven by assumptions rather than evidence.

At the same time, data collection in this space is not straightforward. Employees may be sceptical about how their data will be used, worried about confidentiality, or simply uncomfortable disclosing aspects of their identity to an employer. Poor data collection processes can damage trust rather than building it: mandatory questions, clunky categorisation, or visible gaps between data collected and action taken all undermine participation.

Ethical and effective data collection requires clear communication about purpose, genuine commitment to confidentiality, inclusive question design, and visible action in response to what the data shows. When employees can see that disclosure leads to improvement, participation increases: creating a virtuous cycle in which better data enables better decisions.

FROM THE IMPACT PLATFORM

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